Conditions mixed across Central America as Primera Season ends

The primera season was a mixed bag throughout Central America. From Belize to Nicaragua, rainfall totals were 25 – 75 percent of average for the May to August period. As a result some areas experienced crop losses. In Guatemala, crops were lost in the Jalapa, Zacapa, El Progreso, Baja Verapaz, and Jutiapa departments. In Honduras, the Ministry of Agriculture reports that the poor primera season rains did not affect the national production of crops. However, they have chosen not to distribute seeds to some areas in the departments of Olancho, El Paraiso and Yoro because, according to climatology, they are likely to be affected by drought during the postrera season. The Ministry of Agriculture in El Salvador reports that there is only a 13.7% reduction in crops due to poor primera season rains. In Nicaragua, the municipal boundary of Tola is experiencing drought conditions. Near the municipality of Santa Teresa the majority of the communities lost crops and report low water levels in wells. The low rainfall totals are typical with respect to El Nino.

Postrera Season has a favorable start

The postrera season is off to a more favorable start than the primera season, but remains below average in many areas. The most significant rainfall deficits exist across central Guatemala, central Honduras, and into western Nicaragua. These deficits are ongoing from the primera season. Southern Guatemala, El Salvador, the Gulf of Fonseca, and much of eastern Nicaragua are currently experiencing rainfall totals ranging from 75 – 125 percent of average **(Figure 1)**. Current postrera season rainfall anomalies for these areas are an improvement for the average to below-average primera season **(Figure 2)**.

TRMM Postrera Season Percent of Average Totals
Valid: August 1 – October 5, 2009

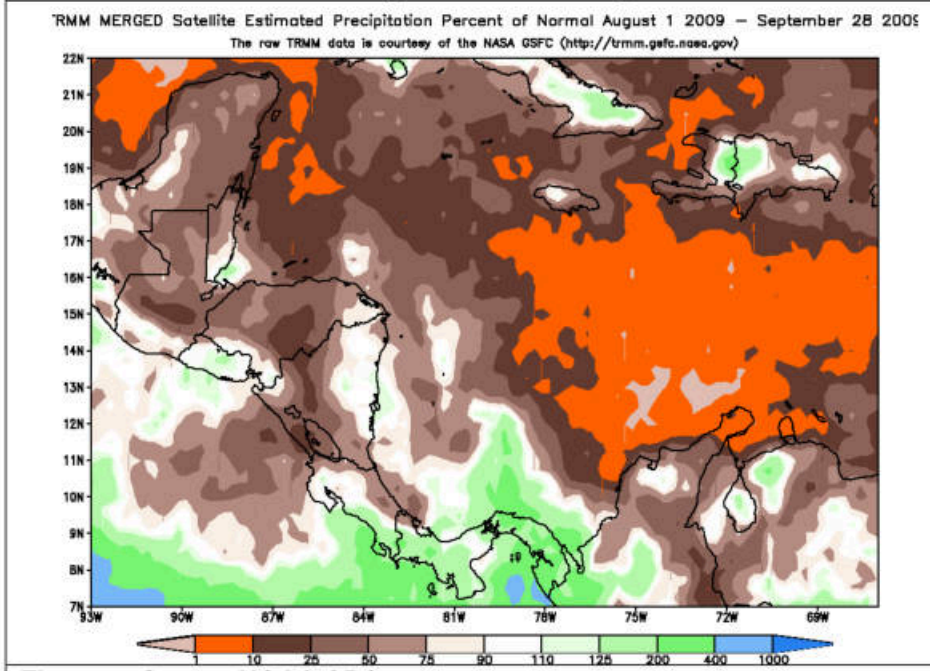


Figure 1: Source NOAA/CPC

TRMM Primera Season Percent of Average Totals
Valid: May 1 – August 31, 2009

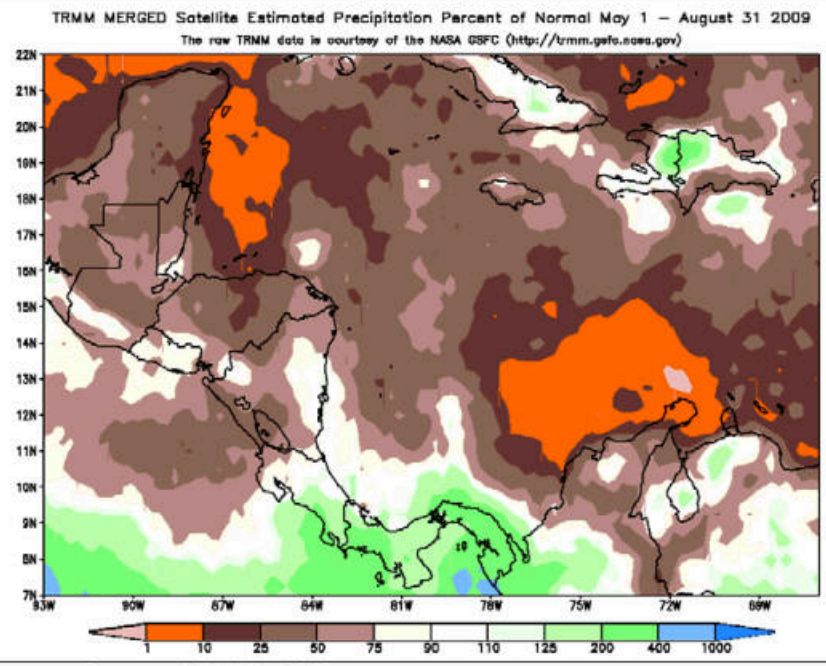


Figure 2: Source NOAA/CPC

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